Chapter 24

Posters and Placards

Sascha Demarmels

General Definition of the Term

A poster is a printed paper, placed in public which adheres to a certain format.[1] Whereas in Germany this format is at least A3 size (standard paper size of 27.9 cm × 42 cm), in Switzerland the so-called Weltformat (128 cm × 90.5 cm) is the standard.[2] The size often depends on the billboards, the official spots to place posters. In the United Kingdom, there are billboards available from four sheets of paper (101.6 cm × 152.4 cm) to 96 sheets.[3] In the United States, however, 9' 7" × 21' 7" (292.1 cm × 657.86 cm) and 10' 5" × 22' 8" (317.5 cm × 690.88 cm) are common formats for poster panels (framed posters in commercial and industrial areas), and bus shelter posters are 4' × 6' (121.92 cm × 182.88 cm).[4] Recently, billposting has become no longer restricted to billboards alone. For example, very big posters are hung on buildings in times of renovations. That is called Building Wrap.[5] The posting is carried out and regulated by an official billposting company. They hang and remove the posters and organize the changing of the billboards.

It is essential that the poster be hung in a central public area where people cannot help but see it. Thus, one can reach lots of people and be guaranteed the message gets to the masses.[6] However, the viewing time has been reduced from 30 to 1.5 seconds since 1940.[7] That means the struggle for attention has been getting harder for the last fifty years.[8] Today, communication with the public does not use posters exclusively anymore but utilizes different channels.[9] In advertising, this is called media-mix: the same campaign appears in different media like on posters, in papers, and on television.[10]

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The codes that can be used in poster communication are basically verbal and visual: pictures, lettering, and color.[11] As for the pictures, printing technology is very important. In 1796, the first step was taken by the invention of the lithography, which allowed for printing pictures in black and white.[12] At the end of the nineteenth century, color lithography brought an aesthetic revolution to the art of poster designing.[13]

Besides the codes, text elements are also essential components of posters. They have been established in the advertising research (see below), but can be used to describe posters in general. Because posters are very large in scale, typography has to be large and pictures cannot hold many details, so that the poster can be read from a distance—there is no use for too detailed of text elements as there are in (paper) advertisements. The main text blocks are the headline (as some kind of title to a poster), the copy or body copy (the main text in several lines as a text block), the slogan, and the logo.[14] However, there are more differences between product and political advertising.[15]

A placard is very similar to a poster and sometimes even used as a synonym. One differentiation is that placards are often more solid because they are made of cardboard. Further, they are not hung up on walls but brought to a demonstration and held in the air, affixed to a stick. For this purpose, they are often not printed but painted by hand. Moreover, there are fewer pictures on placards than on posters, where pictures play a decisive role.

In contrast to other media types, wallpaper is, in fact, less large-scale and has more text in smaller typography. Essentially, it is a newspaper hung up on a wall. Flyers can be seen as the parents of the poster we have today.[16] They have a smaller format and are not hung up but distributed on the streets.[17] And then there are political postcards.[18] They are not very frequent nowadays, but they do have a modern equivalent in the so-called e-cards. You can find them on web sites of political parties and movements for sending via e-mail. They usually consist of a fitting visual motif and/or a slogan. And there is a digital equivalent for the poster, too: public screens in the out-of-home area.[19] All these means of communication are used for advertising products as well as political and social issues. The functions of these media do not change much nor does their general role in culture.

General Cultural Functions

The main goal of posters is to share information, advertising for products and events, political and also social issues. It is about directing attention and persuading people to buy or vote for something. Sometimes the persuasion is very similar to propaganda. Thus, wars have been important in the

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evolution of posters because they were used in an attempt to communicate and manipulate in as efficient a manner as possible.[20] There have been times when political posters were banned from public life because people were overwhelmed by the effect the posters had on them.[21]

The high potential of posters lies especially in the visual aspect. Therefore, multimodality and emotionalization are important research fields (see below).[22] As for art posters, made by actual artists, it is also about aesthetics. Posters are ahead of their time and can absorb actual styles immediately.[23] In this case, posters serve as a vehicle for aesthetic change. They bring art from the museums and galleries out to the streets and to the average person.[24]

Role in Protest Cultures

When Martin Luther started the reformation, he not only had the translated bible printed in a large edition but he also had the possibility of printing pamphlets—comparable with today's flyers—with the new invented printing press. This fact helped him to win his revolution. Without the pamphlets, he probably would not have been capable of communicating with the broad masses.[25]

For protest movements, it was always important to have a means of communication not only to gain the masses but also to communicate at low expense and nevertheless be efficient in communicating. For example, in the 1980s in Switzerland, the youth movement printed their posters with a copy machine. That was cheap and very effective. With the posters they advertised for alternative culture events. This alternative culture was at that time punk, which itself can be seen as a protest against the existing aesthetic standards. "The posters always vexed the general public's habits of seeing."[26] So protest can be manifested already in the poster itself, in the visual part of it, before the content of its verbal text has been read.

Generally, billposting is done officially by some agency; illegal billposting is possible though and often used by protest movements. This reduces costs and draws even more attention to the posters and to the (political) statement.

Yet another form of protest in the area of posters is the so-called adbusting (busting of advertisements). Adbusters alter posters in public to change their message and appeal for a critical view of consumerism. Founder Kalle Lasn wants to get individuals to think critically about advertising.[27] There are several groups of adbusters, often originating in the street art community, who also communicate about their artwork on the Internet via blogs or videos on YouTube.[28] The terms guerilla communication and subvertising

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(from subversive and advertising) are often used in the context of adbusting. They often attract a lot of attention, sometimes even in the classical media.

So, in addition to being effective for communication without costing too much, the role of the poster in protest cultures is to attract interest and to wrap political statements in an aesthetical way. With new signs and perhaps new visual language, there is high potential for recruiting people who may want to be part of the new movement.

Theoretical and Empirical Research Perspectives

As mentioned above, posters are used for advertising. Besides, posters can also be read as art.[29] There are many illustrated books with art historic claims. They assemble posters made by (famous) artists. Then there are collections with posters from a certain area, for example, with political or social posters ("Kunst und Propaganda,"[30] "Political Posters in central and eastern Europe 1945–95,"[31] "Breaking the Rules. Posters from the turbulent 1980s in Switzerland,"[32] "Political and Social Posters of Switzerland"[33]). In these books, the images are central. They are discussed in regard to aesthetics and art history as well as their social functions. Often there are considerations about political behavior too.

Another approach comes from the media sciences with the question of how posters affect recipients and their behavior. This is, though, more technical, and these studies include reflection on the context of posters (city vs. country, traffic situation, and so on).[34] Usually, there are no further thoughts on the visual or verbal contents of posters.

In linguistics, there is a tradition of advertising analysis (mostly about product advertisements in papers), which can be transferred to posters and to the political domain. At first, there were studies about headlines and slogans. It was often in the context of advertising language being a special language. There are also studies comparing the verbal and the visual text in reference to their extent and alignment.[35] In recent years, the concept of multimodality has boomed.[36] There, the visual and verbal texts are analyzed together as a whole. Multimodality means that a text is encoded with different semiotic codes, for example, with pictures and words. There are also studies dealing with different styles of typography.[37]

Because pictures are, like text blocks, a substantial element of posters, they should be examined, therefore, not primarily from an artistic perspective, but rather from the perspective of their communicative function. In this context, emotionalization—the arousal of emotions in the recipients—seems to be important. If one wants to advertise for (or against) something

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(products, political action), one has to gain attention and persuade the target audience. Therefore, emotionalization strategies are often used. They have also not changed much over the years and are similar in different cultures.[38]

Figure 24.1. Appeal for public participation in a Labor Day demonstration and speech (in Europe on May 1st). Poster, anonymous, Museum für Gestaltung Zürich, Plakatsammlung. Franz Xaver Jaggy. © ZHdK.

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Research Gaps and Open Questions

Altogether, posters have not gained much attention in the social sciences and humanities. Most collections are viewed as art rather than analyzed for their context within a certain political movement. Other branches of science do not take posters into account at all. There have been a few studies conducted on election posters in Germany, and there are some books about political movements that include posters.[39] Posters are seen very frequently in our everyday lives. It is a major advantage of this medium that it does not stand out but is being perceived unconsciously. That may be the reason why it is not analyzed that much. Perhaps in the current age of online and offline digital communication, it is also seen as an ancient medium not worth much notice. New media, such as television or the Internet, seem to be more favored subjects of research nowadays.

In regard to protest movements, it would be interesting to investigate the status in current movements like, for example, the occupy movement. Though professional posters are not that cheap anymore, posters and placards can be fabricated at low-cost if necessary. The question would be whether this medium is still attractive to the target group, and perhaps, if this target group is still on the streets, where the posters are hung. Nowadays, a lot of interaction takes place via the Internet where, with social media like Facebook, Twitter, and blogs, there lies a great possibility for immediate exchange and equal participation.

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Notes

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Recommended Reading

Aulich, James, and Marta Sylvestrová. *Political Posters in Central and Eastern Europe 1945–95.* Manchester, 1999. James Aulich and Marta Sylvestrová provide a broad collection of the Soviet posters that had "a decisive political and cultural status"40 and are now looked at from an art historical as well as a politic and sociological perspective.

Chiu, Melissa, and Zheng Shengtian, eds. *Art and China's Revolution.* New York, 2008. Melissa Chiu and Zheng Shengtian assemble in their volume essays from historians, art historians, and artists and invert for once the question about posters and politics by asking how the regime of Mao Zedong influenced the development of aesthetics from the 1950s to the 1970s in China.

Czech, Hans-Jörg, and Nikola Doll. *Kunst und Propaganda im Streit der Nationen 1930–1945.* Dresden, 2007. Hans-Jörg Czech and Nikola Doll allow, with their catalog to an exhibition at the German Historical Museum, a comparison between visual political statements of different states like Italy, Soviet Union, Germany, and the United States from 1930 to 1950. This comparison quarries well-known facts and interpretations but also shows differences, for example between "persuasive strategies of democratic and totalitarian regimes."[41]

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Museum für Gestaltung, ed. *Poster Collection. Breaking the Rules: Posters from the Turbulent 1980s in Switzerland.* Baden, 2007. The poster collection from the Museum für Gestaltung takes a look at the youth movement of the 1980s in Zurich and the new expressivity in the graphic design influenced by the punk movement that led to new innovative visual expressions.

King, David. *Red Star over Russia: A Visual History of the Soviet Union from 1917 to the Death of Stalin. Posters, Photographs and Graphics from the David King Collection.* London, 2009. David King presents the rise and fall of the Soviet Union from 1917 to the death of Stalin, creating the big picture by stringing posters, photographs, and verbal texts from historical relevance. Posters are not in the center but in the midst of these historical processes.

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